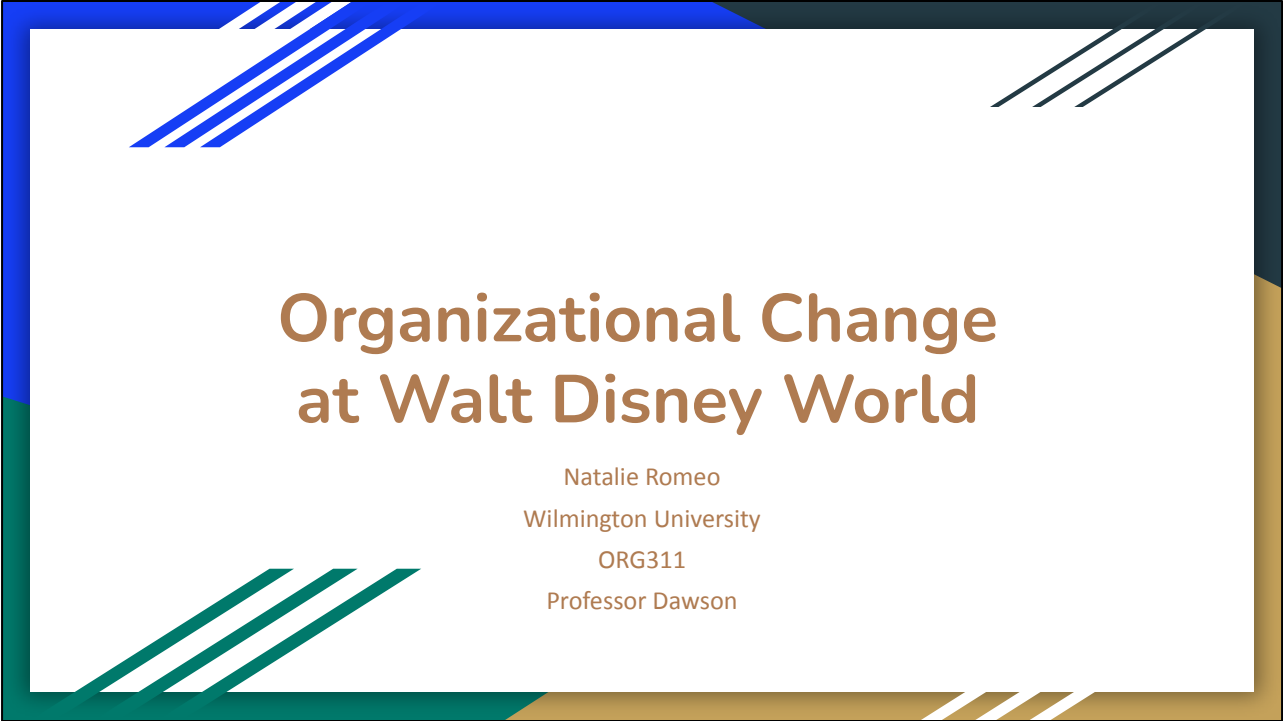




Organizational Change at Walt Disney World

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Disney in a Pandemic

- COVID-19 emerged in early 2020
 - Disney closed in March and reopened in July
 - I was furloughed til November; displaced to Merchandise
- Many people were laid off, furloughed or displaced
 - 32,000 employees across the US were laid off!
- Not everything opened up right away
 - restaurants & hotels
- Limited offerings & limited cast
 - no parades, shows or meet & greets

The organizational change I experienced was how my place of business handled the effects of the COVID-19 pandemic. I work at Walt Disney World and up until the park closed in March 2020, I worked in the entertainment department performing. Everything changed when the pandemic reached the US and when Disney closed in March, myself and so many other employees were put on furlough. When the park reopened in July, nothing was the same, as Disney had to go through an entire redesign process. The parks were operating with extremely limited offerings and capacities for guests and cast members, which led to a huge amount of layoffs, mostly for part time & seasonal. By the end of 2020, Disney laid off 32,000 employees across the country. Those who weren't laid off were full time had to choose to accept a temp transfer or also be laid off. I chose to stay but was displaced in merchandise since my role in entertainment was no longer available for the time being. From November 2020 to September 2021, I got to experience the way an entirely new line of business operated and how they responded to COVID-19. I witnessed so many changes to the company I had been apart of for 5 years.

Forces of Change

- CDC guidelines & recommendations for businesses in this pandemic
 - Masks, 6-feet social distance, frequent sanitation, contactless options
- Temperature checks to enter the parks
 - Cast health screenings & temperature checks to start a work day
- High number of cases in the Orange County area
 - Reducing park capacity, introduce park reservation system
- Vaccination mandate for all working cast members
 - By October 23, everyone should be vaccinated

Of course the main factor for change is the pandemic itself but the CDC developed guidelines for how businesses should continue running under these circumstances. Disney took these into consideration for how to proceed with their operations going forward, despite the challenges of the pandemic. The most major changes at first include the mandatory masks inside and out, maintaining a 6 foot distance between everyone, frequent and obvious sanitation of common touch points, and also contactless options like payments or menus on phones. There were also temp checks required for all guests getting into parks as well as for cast members before starting a work day.

Another major force of change was the constant high number of cases in the orange county area, which is where disney is located. This is where decisions to monitor park capacity and introduce the park reservation system came in. Currently, Disney executives have made the decision to require all working cast members to be fully vaccinated by Oct, 23 to ensure continued employment with the company. This is a major change and big step for Disney which will have a lot of impacts on the future of the organization

Merchandise Changes

- Guests do not pay to get in, no reservation system
 - Track capacity inside stores with counters
- Masks inside every store
 - Every cast member was expected to monitor guests & enforce the policy
- Plexiglass in front of registers
- Social distancing markers on floor
- Cast expected to clean registers & common touch points

First, I'll explain the changes I experienced in the merchandise department. I started working again from furlough last November before anyone could be vaccinated and the pandemic was still pretty scary. The organizational climate at the time was intense, with routine cleanings worked into our daily tasks, strict social distancing expectations, and enforcing masks. We also had the role of door greeter which was simply to count each guest as they came in and out of each store to ensure we did not go over the capacity limit.

We had to anticipate that guests might not cooperate and dealt with some backlash about the new mask rules.

All of this was part of the *informal redesign stage, since some of our roles and expectations did actually change

Entertainment Changes

- Limited offerings, limited cast
 - No advertised meet & greets, no large parades or shows
 - Not enough shifts for every performer = displacement
- Character sightings from a distance
- Masks on for cast members indoors still

Now Ill explain the differences I have noticed since being back in the entertainment department. Right noe, the company is Slowly calling people back to perform again as more offerings become safely available. This entire department that relied so heavily on close contact interactions with guests, hugging, and standing in close proximity with one another, had to completely be redesigned. Decisions had to be made in regards to safety and this unfortunately meant closing shows or changing our roles as performers with a formal redesign process. Since the reopening last year, Everything has had to be outside, but they are currently designing a way for character interactions to resume again in an indoor location.

Organizational Redesign at Disney World

- The complicated process of changing an organization's design elements and structure in response to shifting dynamics in the environment
 - Factor is the pandemic
 - Developing strategies to make theme parks & resorts safe for everyone
 - Informal Redesign Techniques
- Synergies across the other parks to collaborate for effective operations
 - Executives making decisions that apply to all divisions
- Differentiation & integration among departments to come up with new ways of operating
 - Changes in operation at merchandise & entertainment
- Employee commitment to the company's goals
 - Expending individual effort to follow the protocol & ensure guests do as well
 - COVID-19 vaccine mandate

~The change process used here is an organizational redesign. Organizational redesign is defined as The complicated process of changing an organization's design elements and structure in response to shifting dynamics in the environment.... In this case, the factor is the pandemic and the process involves developing strategies to make the theme parks and resorts safe for everyone. This is best categorized as informal redesign arrangements since Disney had to clearly define our roles as cast members during this time, especially regarding all the new safety protocols.

~All parks across property and even across the country had to develop synergies so that they could have accurate communication and collaboration for all operations. This came at the hands of executives to make these decisions.

~Each department, whether it be merchandise, entertainment, attractions, or even custodial had to develop new ways of operating through Differentiation. This is the aspect of developing their own processes & integration is the level of coordination across all departments. The dynamic in entertainment operations has been different than that of merchandise. I noticed differences in how seriously each department took the safety rules especially backstage. Merchandise had social distancing markers backstage spaces but no one wore masks backstage. On the other hand, Everyone in Entertainment is expected to wear masks as soon as you get in from outside and everything is severely sanitized. Differences

~Finally, there must be employee commitment to these new goals of the company. In

order to be succesful in this redesign, all cast members must expend individual effort to follow the protocol and ensure that guests do as well. This committment extends to employees deciding to get the COVID vaccine in order to stay with the company. If everyone does their part, the redesign won't seem so overwhelming of a change and we can hopefully get back to somewhat normal operations in the near future.

Outcomes & Improvements

- Collaboration among cast & departments to develop safe versions of experiences for guests
- Not tracking capacity inside
- More character offerings & interactions, even indoors
 - Full Christmas ticketed event
 - Opening new shows
- More trust among employees to be safe & smart

While All of these changes have been a lot for my organization to undertake, I think they have proven to be successful in allowing operations to run as smoothly as they can during this time. The most prominent outcome has been seeing the collaboration among the cast members & different departments to develop safe versions of experiences for guests. People can still come to Disney, stay in a resort or eat in a restaurant, and even see their favorite character, all while doing it safely. From this redesign, we are moving into “new normal” operations. Disney is no longer tracking capacity in inside locations and more character interactions are being introduced. They are even planning to have a full Christmas ticketed event with shows and parades like in the time before the pandemic. I think the biggest improvement from this is that the company places more trust in its employees to be safe and smart despite all of the new regulations and changes around us.